

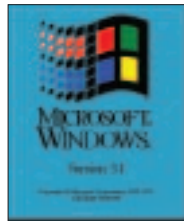
World domination

Today, Windows is the worldwide dominant OS. According to estimates, roughly nine out of 10 computers have a version of Windows installed on them. There are other operating systems in existence — Mac OSX and Linux to name a few, — though no other OS enjoys anything like the success of Microsoft's software. But what exactly is an OS and why do we need one in the first place?

The answer is simple. For your PC to work, it is necessary to have some software that ties together all the various hardware components inside your computer (and out). The OS also provides a user interface of some kind, so that it's possible for people to find your way around, run applications and edit files.

Windows first started appearing on computer screens in 1985. Its name described the way in which the then revolutionary graphical user interface (or GUI) presented window-like panes in which you could organise and navigate your programs and files. We take that for granted these days, but before Windows 1.0, most operating systems simply provided you with a blank screen and a command prompt.

With the launch of Windows 3.1 in 1992, Microsoft coalesced many of its ideas into an OS that is easily identifiable as the foundation stone for the Windows we know and use today. By that stage, Windows was already developing into something more than just a straightforward OS, providing a suite of useful software tools as part of the package. Windows 3.1 came with a File Manager for browsing files and folders, as well as an early version of the Windows Control Panel for customising settings and a modest collection of built-in mini-applications and utilities, including a text editor, a clock, a Print Manager and some familiar games — specifically Minesweeper and Solitaire.



Windows 3.1 was the foundation stone for future OSs



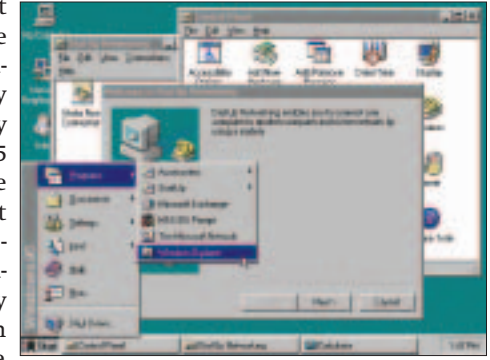
Microsoft's OS has seen many changes over the years

Full of features

As Windows grew, it expanded on a range of built-in applications — known by many as applets. By the time Windows 95 came on the scene three years later, it was positively bristling with extra features and handy tools. It was in Windows 95 that we first saw the Start button and Start

Menu, for example — something relatively small but significant enough to remain a central part of Windows right up to Vista. Also included were Windows Explorer, a Search function, networking features, a media player, a sound recorder and a fully customisable desktop, all of which can still be found in Windows today.

Over the years, subsequent Windows releases have brought with them even more features. Windows 98 introduced USB support. Windows ME came with a broader range of internet and multimedia tools, including the video-editing application Windows Movie Maker. In 2001, Windows XP provided the biggest revamp of Microsoft's OS till date. It was built using a completely different architecture to previous consumer editions of Windows and featured a radically overhauled graphical interface. It also had a startling array of applets, features and options. XP's Control Panel came with loads of tweaks and settings that allowed you to customise your experience. Its built-in Media Player was a proper grown-up music and movie program, with streaming capabilities, CD ripping and burning functions and a library-type interface. Crucially, XP was fully internet-ready — well, almost. Its arrival happily coincided with the proliferation of home broadband connections and its built-in networking, web browsing and email functions made it easy for users to get online and make the most of what the net had to offer. However, early editions of XP were heavily criticised for their lack of security features. In order to protect their PCs against internet-borne threats such as viruses, hack-



Windows 95 brought with it the popular Start button